Bombay, Sir Henry Bartle Edward Frere, and a foreman, on the Bhore Ghat Railway incline.

Building the railroad over the Bhore and Thull ghats in western India was a tough challenge. The massive construction for both the lines went on for more than seven years, and about 25,000 people worked at the site at any given time .

While the workers were native men, women and children, the foremen and supervisors were English. Brunton recalls that the governor and his party on a visit to Bhore Ghat approached a party of workers. Besides a big team of labourers he encountered ‘a brawny navvy’, as he mentions, an Englishman who appeared to be superintending operations. Sir Frere addressed him in his mild, kind way. [55]

> ‘Well, my good man, you appear to be the manager here.’
> ‘Yes, sir,’ was the reply.
> ‘And how are you getting on?’
> ‘Oh, sir, we are getting on well.’
> ‘How many natives you have under your orders?’
> ‘Well, sir, about 500 of ’em all together.’
> ‘Do you speak their language?’
> ‘No sir, I don’t.’
> ‘Well, then, how do you manage to let these natives understand what they are to do?’
> ‘Oh, sir, I’ll tell you. I tell these chaps three times in good plain English, and if they don’t understand that, I take the lukri (the stick) and we get on well.’
>
> The ludicrousness of the whole situation was too much for Sir Frere’s gravity and he burst out laughing—and [the Englishmen] were obliged to turn away. They discovered that this navvy was a most kind-hearted fellow, much loved by the natives under his charge, who would do anything for him. He, of course, when he made the confession, had no idea to whom he was speaking.

RAIL CARRIAGES FOR CASTE, CLASS AND THE MASSES

In south India, where the trial runs of the railways and makeshift locomotives had happened way back in the 1830s, the construction of formal passenger railways had now been taken up.

The first Madras Railway Company was established in 1845. After facing many difficulties while getting started, the company was dissolved in 1847. In July 1852 (under a deed of settlement) the Madras Railway Company was formally created in the City of London ‘for the purpose of acquiring and holding lands in the East Indies and Great Britain, and making, acquiring and working one or more railway or railways in India’